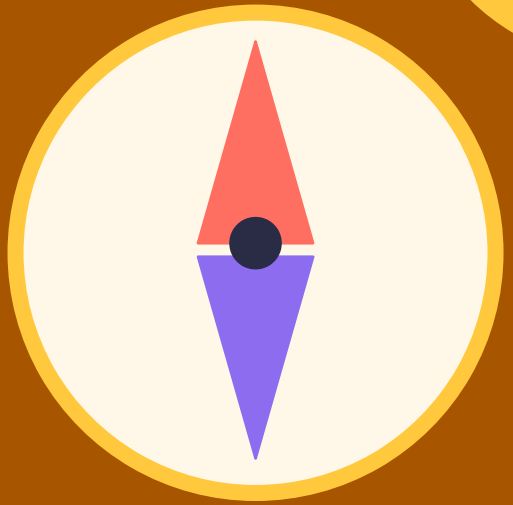
Child-centred Learning: Responding to Every Child



Pembelajaran yang Berpusat pada Anak: Menanggapi Setiap Anak

Module 3 | Dr Craig Sims

Curriculum as a Compass for Learning in Early Childhood Education

About me | Tentang saya

Who I am

Senior Lecturer in Learning Technologies, School of Education, Curtin University.

Academic Lead: Digital Pedagogies.

PhD in Education (2025).

What I do

I teach teachers how to teach well in a digital world.

I coordinate a graduate certificate in higher education, in innovative learning and teaching.

What I research

AI in education.

Immersive learning environments for students who are often left out.

Teacher development and attitudes to STEM.

Associate Investigator, ARC Centre of Excellence for the Digital Child.

Your assessment: the portfolio

What you produce

One portfolio.

It brings together one piece from each module, Modules 1 to 5.

What you present

One curriculum goal travelling from intention, to experience, to evidence, to improvement.

When

At the assessment and presentation session at the end of the program.

Your portfolio is one separate file. Each module gives you one piece. Today's piece is your learner profile.

How your portfolio builds

Now

Fill in your details.

Choose one curriculum goal, and say why.

Check what you already have from Modules 1 and 2.

After each module

Add that module's piece.

Tick it on your checklist.

Keep following the same goal.

At the assessment session

Talk about your goal, from intention to improvement.

Your portfolio is what you talk from.

It is one file. Keep adding to it.

Your first five minutes

Step 1

Open the portfolio file from the chat or the program page.

Step 2

Fill in your details (page 2).

Step 3

Choose your curriculum goal, and write why (page 2).

Step 4

Look at your Module 1 and Module 2 pieces (pages 3 and 4).

Page 7 is your presentation plan. You will add to it as the program goes on.

Module 3: Child-centred Learning

Pembelajaran yang Berpusat pada Anak

Where we are in the program

1. Curriculum as a Living Guide
2. Planning for Holistic Foundational Development
3. **Child-centred learning (you are here)**
4. Assessment for Learning
5. Strengthening Curriculum Implementation

What you will be able to do today

Part 1 See each child | Part 2 Change the pathway | Part 3 Design the task | Part 4 Plan and check

LO 1 | Part 1	Describe what child-centred and developmentally appropriate practice looks like in a classroom, starting from children's interests, strengths and needs.
LO 2 | Part 1	Notice a child's capability and what may get in the way of taking part, before looking at labels.
LO 3 | Parts 2, 3 and 4	Adjust a planned experience so every child can take part and show understanding, changing the pathway but keeping the learning goal.
LO 4 | Parts 3 and 4	Weigh where technology, including unplugged activities, can personalise learning and where it gets in the way.
LO 5 | Part 4	Decide what to watch for, to tell whether a support is helping or hiding a child's learning.

Your worksheet for today

This is for Module 3 only. It is separate from your portfolio. Download the Word file from the link in the chat.

Page 1: Table 1

Class snapshot: one row for every child.

Page 2: Table 2

Learner profile for planning.

Page 3: Table 3

Toolkit of supports: tick what you could use.

Page 4

AI prompt cards for your planning.

Type in the Word file, or print it and write by hand. We will fill it in as we go.

How this builds on Modules 1 and 2

Module 1: Professor Karen Murcia

- A compass, not a script: direction without prescribing every step.
- Four layers: intended, planned, enacted, experienced. Adjustments happen in the enacted layer.
- Evidence first: describe what you see and hear before you interpret.

Module 2: Dr Emma Cross

- Six questions for planning. Today goes deeper on question 1: What do I know about these children? And question 3: What experience or environment might make this possible?
- Mindful, meaningful, joyful (berkesadaran, bermakna, menggembirakan).

The Leaves plan

In Module 2, every child copied the word LEAF, counted five leaves on a worksheet and made the same collage from a model.

Today we ask: who could not take part, and how could we change the pathway and keep the goal?

Three ideas guide this module

Child-centred does not mean educator-passive. The educator chooses, listens, notices and adjusts.

Child-centred and developmentally appropriate

Meaning Practice that starts from the children and suits where they are in their development (berpusat pada anak).

In the market corner Children can count the items by carrying them, drawing them or saying them aloud, so each child starts where they are.

Interests, needs and development

Meaning Knowing what each child is interested in, needs, and how they are developing.

In the market corner Watch who carries the items, who draws the dots and who says the numbers.

Meaningful, engaging experiences

Meaning Experiences that matter to the children and hold their attention.

In the market corner A market is familiar to many children, so buying and selling means something to them.

Pace and choice

Natural pace

Meaning Child-centred practice respects each child's natural pace of development and learning.

In the market corner Arif finishes quickly and takes on more. Lina has time to speak when she is ready.

Choice

Meaning Children have freedom to choose from activities that suit their needs, interests and potential.

In the market corner Children choose how to show the count: carry items, draw dots or say the number.

Slow education

Meaning Less content, a slower pace and deeper involvement (Catalano et al., 2023).

In the market corner One stall, a whole morning, instead of three short tasks.

Catalano et al. (2023) surveyed 376 Romanian teachers after in-service training. It shows changes in teacher thinking, not child outcomes.

Meet Dewa, Lina and Arif

Fictional children, as in the online work. Start with what each child can do. Then think about what may get in the way.

Dewa (5)

Capability Learns by moving and building. Leads block play, balances carefully and keeps trying when a tower falls.

May get in the way Sitting still for a long story or whole-group talk is very hard. He often wanders away.

Lina (5)

Capability Understands much more than she says. Draws detailed pictures and explains them in her home language to a friend.

May get in the way She is quiet in group talk. At home she speaks a language other than Bahasa Indonesia.

Arif (5)

Capability Reads simple words and counts to 100.

May get in the way Finishes quickly and gets bored with repeated tasks. Waiting for a turn and sharing are hard, and he sometimes disrupts others.

Capability, barrier, adjustment

Change the pathway when the barrier is about access. Keep the learning goal.

Capability (kemampuan)

Meaning What the child can already do, know or contribute.

Example Lina draws detailed pictures and explains them to a friend.

Barrier (hambatan)

Meaning What stops the child showing it: the task, the room, the language, the pace, the way of responding.

Example Quiet in group talk, so what she knows is not seen.

Adjustment (penyesuaian)

Meaning A change that removes the barrier. It should not change the learning goal.

Example She shows the count with drawn dots and tells a friend first, then the class.

From the curriculum to a learning goal

1. The curriculum says

Example Australian Curriculum, Mathematics, Foundation.

AC9MFN02 Name how many objects are in a collection of up to 5.

AC9MFN03 Count and compare collections, and explain the reasoning.

2. Your learning goal

Count out the right number of items to match a price (up to 5).

One specific thing a child does in this experience.

3. What you see

A child sets out the right number of items for a price.

They show or tell you how they know.

In Indonesia: the CP is the broad statement. The TP is the goal you write for one experience.

Australian Curriculum v9: Mathematics, Foundation. © ACARA.

Your turn: the market corner

Same goal for all: count out the right number of items for a price. What would you change?

Dewa (5)

Capability Moves and builds. Leads block play.

May get in the way A long wait, and sitting still to listen.

Lina (5)

Capability Understands more than she says. Draws detailed pictures.

May get in the way Quiet in group talk, so her counting is not seen.

Arif (5)

Capability Reads simple words and counts to 100.

May get in the way Repeated tasks. Waiting and sharing.

In the chat: write one adjustment for Dewa, Lina or Arif. You have 2 minutes.

Worked example: the market corner, adjusted

The same experience and the same goal. A different pathway for each child.

Dewa (5)

Capability Moves and builds. Leads block play.

May get in the way A long wait, and sitting still to listen.

Adjustment Counts by moving: carries the items to the stall one at a time and says the number as he goes. Real items, not a worksheet.

Lina (5)

Capability Understands more than she says. Draws detailed pictures and explains them to a friend.

May get in the way Quiet in group talk, so her counting is not seen.

Adjustment Draws dots on the price sign to show the count. Counts aloud to a friend first, then to a small group, then to the class.

Arif (5)

Capability Reads simple words and counts to 100.

May get in the way Repeated tasks. Waiting and sharing.

Adjustment Counts higher, to 20, and writes the numerals on the price signs. Checks the others' counting. Clear start and finish.

Same goal for all three: count out the right number of items to match a price (up to 5). Your goal comes from your curriculum.

Discussion points

Think, then chat. About two minutes on each.

1

What stayed the same for all three children?

What changed?

2

In each adjustment, who is doing the thinking: the child or the adult?

3

Did any change lower the goal?

Where could you add challenge?

Children's goal: count out the right number of items for a price

Discussion points: the key ideas

Compare with what you said.

1. Same goal, new pathway

The learning goal stayed the same for all three children.

What changed is how each child gets there: the pathway.

2. Who does the thinking?

The child should do more of their own thinking over time.

If the adult does the thinking, the support hides learning.

3. Keep the challenge

A change lowers the goal when the child no longer does the thinking the goal asks for. Colouring in a corner would.

Making the price signs extends it.

Children's goal: count out the right number of items for a price

What kind of change is it?

Which change the pathway? Which lower the goal? Which extend the challenge? Chat your numbers.

Six examples from your online work

1. Lina may explain her thinking first to a friend in her home language, then to the class.
2. Dewa takes part only in a colouring corner, away from the group.
3. Arif is invited to make the price signs and check the others' counting.
4. Dewa may stand and move between stations while the story is read.
5. Lina is asked to repeat words after the teacher until she says them correctly.
6. All children may show their counting with objects, drawings or words.

What kind of change is it? The answer

Changes the pathway

- Lina may explain her thinking first to a friend in her home language, then to the class.
- Dewa may stand and move between stations while the story is read.
- All children may show their counting with objects, drawings or words.

Lowers the goal

- Dewa takes part only in a colouring corner, away from the group.
- Lina is asked to repeat words after the teacher until she says them correctly.

Test If the child no longer does the thinking the goal asks for, the goal has been lowered.

Extends the challenge

- Arif is invited to make the price signs and check the others' counting.

Test The goal stays the same, and the child is stretched further.

Hold this thought. A change to the pathway lowers the floor. Extending the challenge raises the ceiling. A floor set too low lowers the goal. We come back to this after the break.

Children's goal: count out the right number of items for a price

Three levels of planning

Level 1: every child

What A snapshot row: capability, what may get in the way, adjustment, what I will watch for.

Time About a minute for each child.

Level 2: children who need more

What A one-page learner profile for planning: the same goal, with the pathways and supports written down.

For Two or three children at a time.

Level 3: the formal PPI

What The formal individual learning plan: Program Pembelajaran Individual (PPI), for children with identified additional needs, with specialist support.

Note The goal itself may change.

Table 1: Class snapshot

Worksheet page 1. One row for every child. The example is Lina.

Capability	May get in the way	Adjustment	I will watch for
Understands more than she says. Draws detailed pictures and explains them to a friend.	Quiet in group talk, so her counting is not seen.	Draws dots on the sign to show the count. Counts aloud to a friend first, then to a small group, then to the class.	Does she count out the right number, and say it aloud to the group, over the next few weeks?

One row for every child, about a minute each. No names are needed. The last box becomes your evidence in Module 4.

Break

15 minutes | Istirahat

We will return at: _____

Covered so far: LO 1, 2 and 3. After the break: LO 3, 4 and 5.

A toolkit of supports

Kotak peralatan dukungan

Many of the best supports are simple, low-cost and made by teachers.

A toolkit of supports

Worksheet page 3, Table 3: tick three you could use.

Visual routine or picture cards (kartu gambar)

Steps shown in pictures, so a child can check what comes next.

Home-language words and peer buddies (teman sebaya)

Key words in the home language. A buddy supports, and does not do it for the child.

Choice of where and how to work (pilihan)

A job, a place, or a way to show what they know.

Movement and breaks (gerak)

Move between stations, stand to listen, take a short break.

Real objects and loose parts (benda nyata)

Count and build with real things, not only pictures.

Clear start and clear finish (awal dan akhir yang jelas)

Say what the task is, and what done looks like.

Room set-up and seating (penataan ruang)

Space to move, a quiet corner, who sits where.

Asking the family (bertanya pada keluarga)

What helps at home? What does the child enjoy?

Two ways to make room for every child

Design the task

What One task with a low floor and a high ceiling, so most children can start and go further without a separate adjustment.

Where Part 3 now: one task, three pathways.

Adjust for a child

What A change for one child, like Dewa, Lina and Arif in the worked example.

Where Part 2, and the learner profile in Part 4.

Most children need only a well-designed task. A few need the task and an adjustment.

One task, many ways in

The task

Task Coming into the classroom: hang up your coat, get your things out, sit at your table, wait for the teacher to start.

Learning goal Our example: the child follows the entry routine and is at their seat, ready. Use your own from your curriculum. It stays the same for every child.

Children Aged 5. Some need a lot of support to get there, and some can do more.

Your turn: 2 minutes

Think, then chat.

How would you set this up so every child ends up at their seat, and each gets the support they need?

Children's goal: be at their seat, ready, when the teacher starts

Low floor, high ceiling

Low floor

Easy to start. Every child can begin, with the right support.

Dewa and Lina needed a lower floor.

High ceiling

Room to go further. No child runs out of challenge.

Arif needed a higher ceiling.

Same task, same goal

All children work on the same task at once, at different depths. They can move between pathways.

The idea comes from designing tools for children's coding (Resnick & Silverman, 2005) and is used to differentiate in classrooms (McClure, Woodham & Borthwick, 2011). See also Su & Yang (2023).

Children's goal: be at their seat, ready, when the teacher starts

Idea 1: Show the steps

Same goal: be at your seat, ready.

Low floor

A picture strip, one picture for each step.

A buddy points to each picture with the child.

High ceiling

A written list, or no list at all.

The child checks the steps and helps a friend.

Quick with AI or technology

AI drafts the step wording in Bahasa Indonesia and English, and a strip to print.

A tablet or phone camera turns photos of your own classroom into the cards.

Check The steps match your room.

Watch for: following the pictures, then the list, then doing it with neither.

Children's goal: be at their seat, ready, when the teacher starts

Idea 2: Act it out and model it

Same goal: be at your seat, ready.

Low floor

You or a buddy walk the steps with the child, in the same order every day.

Say each step as you do it.

High ceiling

The child leads: they show a friend the steps, and say them aloud.

Quick with AI or technology

AI drafts a short chant of the steps in Bahasa Indonesia, at three lengths.

A tablet voice recording lets a child hear the steps and practise.

Check Is the Indonesian natural?

Watch for: copying the steps, then doing them with a prompt, then leading them.

Idea 3: Fade the support

Same goal: be at your seat, ready.

Low floor

Start with modelling and pictures.

Use the same steps in the same order every day.

High ceiling

Move to a list, then to nothing.

The child does the steps alone, and helps a friend.

Quick with AI or technology

AI drafts the same steps at three levels: pictures, a list, and one reminder word.

A visual timer on a phone or tablet shows when the teacher will start.

Check Does every level end at the same seat?

Watch for: how many steps the child does before looking at the support. A support that never fades hides the learning.

Children's goal: be at their seat, ready, when the teacher starts

Technology: help or get in the way?

A review of 26 studies found children aged 3 to 8 can build early computational thinking (berpikir komputasional: sequencing, spotting patterns, fixing mistakes), and communication and collaboration, when activities suit their age (Su & Yang, 2023).

Unplugged or plugged

Unplugged No devices (tanpa perangkat digital): direction cards, putting story cards in order, acting out the steps of "bathing the baby".

Plugged Robots or tablets (dengan perangkat).

Low floor, high ceiling

Easy to start with (a low floor) and room to build more complex solutions (a high ceiling).

This could suit children who need different starting points, such as Lina and Arif (Su & Yang, 2023).

Equity and open questions

Equity Girls tend to be put off by boy-dominated robotics toys, which may lead to digital inequity.

Open Few valid ways to assess young children's computational thinking. Most studies come from developed countries.

Helping or hiding?

Which help the learning, and which hide it? Chat your answer.

Three examples

1. Lina starts by explaining to a friend, then adds words in Bahasa Indonesia herself over the weeks.
2. The adult tells Dewa the price.
3. Lina's buddy always answers for her.

What would you watch for to tell the difference?

Helping or hiding? The answer

What you notice here becomes the evidence you will work with in Module 4, on assessment.

It helps

When The child does more of their own thinking over time.

Example Lina starts by explaining to a friend, then adds words in Bahasa Indonesia herself over the weeks.

It hides learning

When The support, or the adult, does the thinking for the child.

Example The adult tells Dewa the price. Lina's buddy always answers for her.

For your child: what will you watch for? What would be a sign the support is hiding learning?

Using AI to draft the pathways

A planning helper for you, not a tool for the children. Worksheet page 4 has prompt cards.

Example prompt

Act as a planning assistant for an early childhood teacher in Indonesia. The task is: children coming into the classroom, hanging up the coat, getting their things out, sitting at the table and waiting for the teacher to start. The children are aged 5. The goal is [for example: the child follows the entry routine and is at their seat, ready].

Write three versions of the same routine: (1) with pictures and a buddy, (2) with a written list, (3) with one reminder word. Keep the same goal in all three. Give the step wording in Bahasa Indonesia and English.

Do not include any child's name or personal details. Tell me where a version might lower the goal.

You still check

- Do all three versions end at the seat, ready?
- Is the easiest one still the same routine?
- Is the Indonesian natural?
- Does it fit your room?

No AI? A tablet or phone camera, a printer, a voice recorder or the printed templates also help.

Before you use AI with children's information

Five habits

- Leave out names, photos, assessments, diagnoses and anything that could identify a child.
- Check every item before any child sees it.
- Keep your own observation as the evidence of learning.
- Keep a no-device version ready.
- Follow your school's rules and the Ministry's guide for teachers.

Ministry of Primary and Secondary Education, Republic of Indonesia. (2025/2026). Panduan pemanfaatan kecerdasan artifisial: untuk Guru Pendidikan Anak Usia Dini, Pendidikan Dasar, dan Pendidikan Menengah. repositori.kemendikdasmen.go.id/36443

Table 2: Learner profile for planning

Worksheet page 2. For children who need more than a snapshot row.

About the child

Age and home language(s). No name.

Interests and likes.

Strengths.

Five areas, three steps

Areas Communication and language, social interaction, behaviour and emotions, sensory and movement, learning and attention.

Steps What I notice, impact in the classroom, key adjustments.

Then plan the task

The task and its three pathways.

The pathway this child starts on, and a support from the toolkit.

What I will watch for.

Same thinking as Table 1: what I notice is the capability, the impact is what may get in the way, and the key adjustments are the adjustment.

Using the profile

Choose the pathway

For each task, decide which pathway the child starts on.

Keep it up to date

Add what you notice. Change an adjustment when it stops helping.

Share it

Share it with the family and your colleagues. No names or photos in any AI tool.

Use it as evidence

“What I will watch for” is your evidence for Module 4. Look at it again after about four weeks.

Example: Lina's profile

About Lina (fictional)

Age 5. Quiet in group talk.

Likes drawing.

Strengths: draws detailed pictures, and understands more than she says.

Communication and language

Notice Explains her pictures to a friend.

Impact Quiet in group talk, so her counting is not seen.

Adjustment Draws dots to show the count. Counts to a friend first, then the class.

The plan

Task The market corner.

Starts on The easy start, with dots and a friend.

Support Picture cards (kartu gambar).

Watch for Counting aloud to the group, over a few weeks.

Try it on your own

About 8 minutes. Work through it at your own pace, then share one idea if you like.

Step 1

Choose three children in your class, real or imagined. No names.

Step 2

Write a snapshot row for each (Table 1, page 1).

Step 3

For one child, complete the learner profile (Table 2, page 2), with three pathways for a task you run.

Step 4

Share one idea in the chat if you would like to.

Optional: use the example prompt to draft the three pathways, then check every item. Keep the child's details out of the prompt.

Key points to take away

Capability before barrier (LO 2)

Start with what the child can do, before what gets in the way. Record it for every child.

Change the pathway, keep the goal (LO 3)

One task with an easy start and room to go further. The goal never drops.

Helping, not hiding (LO 5)

The child should do more of their own thinking over time.

AI drafts, you decide (LO 4)

You observe, check and choose. Keep children's details out of AI tools.

Before we finish

1. Finish Table 2

Where Worksheet page 2.

What One child, one task. A phrase or a sentence in each box.

2. Add to your portfolio

Where Portfolio page 5.

What Paste your Table 2, and tick Module 3 on your checklist.

3. Check the outcomes

In the chat, rate LO 1 to 5, from 1 (not yet) to 4 (confident).

ONE IDEA TO TAKE WITH YOU

Change the pathway, keep the goal.

Next module: assessment for learning, the evidence these experiences produce.